Orlando

By Andrea Gibson

(Pg 11-15) When the first responders

entered the Pulse nightclub

after the massacre in Orlando,

they walked through the horrific scene

of bodies and called out,

"If you are alive, raise your hand."

I was sleeping in a hotel

in the Midwest at the time,

but I imagine in that exact moment,

my hand twitched in my sleep,

some unconscious part of me aware

that I had a pulse

that I was alive . . . .

INTRODUCTION

June 12, 2016. Saturday night was Latin Night at Pulse, one of Orlando, Florida's best-known gay clubs. The place was packed with patrons both gay and straight, young and not-so-young, from the U.S., Puerto Rico, the Dominican Republic, Mexico and elsewhere. Everyone was having a good time, dancing salsa and bachata until

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2:02 am when all hell broke loose. When the dust settled, 49 people were confirmed dead and 53 others injured it what was, at the time, the deadliest mass shooting in US history. The deadliest until the following October when shots rang out again at a music festival in Las Vegas, Nevada.

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(con't) . . . The next day I woke to the news

that an assault rifle had fired

202 bullets through a gay bar

on Latin night in one of the worst

massacres in US history -- a massacre

of people who did not leave the dance floor

when they heard gunshots

because they thought

they were just the beats

of the song.

Everyone around me spent

that day grieving and every tear

tasted like dance sweat

drying in the morgue.

Later that night

I was performing for an audience

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that had spent two hours in line
waiting to get through bag checks
and metal detectors. On stage
I couldn't keep my hand
from covering

my heart. Kept searching
the club for the fastest route
to every exit. I knew the person
working security was in a text war
and wasn't keeping his eyes
on the door; I knew there was a man
in the fifth row picking at the seams
of a red duffel bag.

Every few seconds
I'd eye the balcony
for the glint
of whatever might aim
to tear the bodies
off the boys holding hands
or the girls with the haircuts short
as my temper when rage

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is a decibel I can actually get to
when I not just frozen
and grief-sick watching history

not be history, watching
the music not be music, knowing
someone having the best night of her life
shouted, ***This is my favorite song,***
and then a drumbeat lifted

a rifle over a bathroom stall
and emptied a magazine
into the kidneys of a grown man
texting, ***Mommy I'm going to die***,
his handprints in blood
on the walls, reaching

for people
dying in the fetal position.
People covered in their friend's blood,
crying too hard to hide
from their own deaths,
people outside pushing
bandannas into bullet wounds.

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It's true
what they say about the gays
being so fashionable --
our ghosts never go
out of style.

even life is like funeral practice:
half of us already dead
to our families before we die.
half of us on our knees
trying to crawl
into the family photo.

That night on stage I kept remembering
being fifteen at Disney World
wearing my best friend's hoodie

like it was my boyfriend's
class ring.

How many years it took me
to just touch her face.
how many years of praying
my heart could play dead

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until the threat was gone
until the world changed

until history was history,
but history just keeps coming
for the high, keeps shooting up
bodies, keeps drumming up reasons

to have metal detectors
at poetry readings
where the poems feel
like unanswered calls
to people who claim their god
or their apathy, is unwilling
to accept the charges.

Dear god, how broke
do you have to be
to not buy people time
to get out the door
when the song
goes to f****** hell?

When this world, drunk
on hate, decides blood

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is wine and drinks its fill

in the only place

they ever thought was safe?

In the only place they thought

they didn't have to hide?

In the only place they were wanted

because of who they loved

and how they loved

and how they loved

until someone walked through their bodies

and asked who was still alive

and hardly anyone

put their hand up.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2025 National Qualifier
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